

M03b: Meaning units within words

There is one more word-formation process which you use every day but might not yet understand: Building words from meaning parts that are smaller than words. This is called 'derivation'.

Derivation is a way of creating new words by adding prefixes (at the beginning) or suffixes (at the end).

Prefix	Suffix
Prefixes change the meaning but keep the word class (an adjective stays an adjective). <i>happy → unhappy</i>	Suffixes often change the word class. <i>teach → teacher</i> (verb → noun)

Derivation helps you understand unfamiliar words and build your vocabulary more efficiently. Here are some of the most common pre- and suffixes in English.

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un- / in- / im- /ir- / il- / non-	not	unfair, inactive, impolite, irregular, illegal, nonsense
re-	again	reread
de-	reverse / remove / down	defrost, de-escalate, demote (vs. promote)
dis-	not / opposite of	disconnect
super- vs. sub-	above/beyond vs. under/below	superman vs. submarine (below water)
over- vs. under-	too much / above vs. too little / below	overworked vs. underpaid

Suffix	Meaning	Examples
-er / -or	person who does	teacher, actor
-ist	person who practices sth.	artist
-ian	related to sth.	musician
-ment / -tion / -sion / -ion	action, result, process, condition	movement, education, decision
-ity / -ance / -ence	state or quality	reality, importance, difference
-ing	action or process	writing
-ful / -ous	full of / having a lot	helpful, famous
-less	without / having little	careless
-able / -ible	can be done	readable, visible

Explain the meaning of words

Use the tables on page 1 to explain the meaning of the words below. For each word, write down the pre- and suffixes you can find in it. Then, describe the meaning of the complete word.

irreality	
rewrite	
creation	
a misunderstanding	
distrustful	
respectability	
impossibility	
antidisestablish- mentarianism	

Build some words yourself

Start with a noun or verb you like. Add some pre- or suffixes and see what happens. Make your table group guess what your words could mean.

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